

# Class 8 History Chapter 5: When People Rebel (1857 and After)

## 1. Policies and the People: Nawabs Lose Their Power

- **Loss of Authority:** Over time, the British took away the freedom, armed forces, and revenues of Indian Nawabs and Rajas through policies like the Subsidiary Alliance and the Doctrine of Lapse.
- **Failed Negotiations:** Rulers tried to negotiate with the Company but failed. For example, Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi wanted her adopted son recognized as the heir, and Nana Saheb wanted his late father's pension. Both were refused.
- **Awadh Annexed:** In 1856, the British took over Awadh, claiming it was being misgoverned.
- **End of the Mughal Era:** The British systematically planned to end the Mughal dynasty. Governor-General Canning declared that Bahadur Shah Zafar would be the last Mughal King, and his descendants would only be recognized as "princes."

## 2. The Peasants and the Sepoys

- **Peasants:** In the countryside, peasants and zamindars were furious over heavily high taxes. Many lost their lands because they couldn't pay back loans taken from moneylenders.
- **Sepoys (Indian Soldiers):** The sepoy were unhappy with their pay, allowances, and harsh conditions of service.
- **The Sea Route Issue (1824):** Sepoys refused to go to Burma via the sea because of a widespread belief that crossing the sea would cause them to lose their religion and caste. In response, the Company passed a law making it mandatory for new recruits to agree to travel overseas if required.

## 3. Responses to British Reforms

- The British passed laws to stop the practice of **Sati** and to encourage **widow remarriage**. They also heavily promoted English education.
- Christian missionaries were allowed to function freely. In 1850, a new law allowed Indians who converted to Christianity to inherit their ancestors' property.
- Because of these reforms, many Indians began to feel that the British were intentionally destroying their traditional religion and social customs.

## 4. A Mutiny Becomes a Popular Rebellion (From Meerut to Delhi)

- **The Spark:** The British introduced new rifle cartridges that were heavily suspected to be greased with the fat of cows and pigs. This deeply angered both Hindu and Muslim sepoy.

- **8 April 1857:** Mangal Pandey was hanged to death for attacking his officers.
- **The Meerut Mutiny:** On 9 May, 85 sepoys in Meerut were sentenced to 10 years in jail for refusing to use the new cartridges. The next day (10 May), other soldiers rebelled, attacked the jail, freed the sepoys, killed British officers, and declared war on the "Firangis" (foreigners).
- **March to Delhi:** The soldiers marched to Delhi and proclaimed the aging Mughal Emperor, **Bahadur Shah Zafar**, as their leader. He then wrote letters to all the chiefs and rulers of India to organize a confederacy of Indian states to fight the British.

## 5. The Rebellion Spreads

- The rebellion quickly spread to other parts of the country. Local leaders and rulers joined the fight, including:
  - **Nana Saheb** in Kanpur
  - **Begum Hazrat Mahal** in Lucknow
  - **Rani Lakshmibai** and **Tantia Tope** in Jhansi
  - **Kunwar Singh** in Bihar
  - **Bakht Khan** (a soldier) in Bareilly
  - **Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah** in Faizabad

## 6. The Company Fights Back & The Aftermath

- **Suppression:** The British brought reinforcements from England and recaptured Delhi in September 1857. Bahadur Shah Zafar was sentenced to life imprisonment and sent to a prison in Rangoon. Rani Lakshmibai was defeated and killed in 1858. Tantia Tope fought a guerrilla war but was ultimately caught and killed in 1859.
- **Changes Introduced After the Revolt (Act of 1858):**
  1. **Transfer of Power:** The powers of the East India Company were officially transferred to the **British Crown** to ensure better management of Indian affairs.
  2. **Rights of Rulers:** All ruling chiefs were assured that their territory would never be annexed in the future, provided they acknowledged the British Queen as their Sovereign Paramount.
  3. **Army Restructuring:** The number of Indian soldiers was drastically reduced, and European soldiers were increased. Recruitment shifted away from Awadh and Bihar, and more soldiers were recruited from the Gurkhas, Sikhs, and Pathans.
  4. **Respect for Customs:** The British promised not to interfere with the religious and social practices of the Indian people. Policies were also made to protect landlords and zamindars to win back their loyalty.